They exchanged the goods from various parts of Asia with the Italians, who then traded on them in Europe. The European powers, particularly Portugal and Spain, wanted to have direct trade with the Asian countries. They therefore encouraged the exploration of new routes, so that they could profit more. This was the decisive economic factor that provided the urge to discover new trade routes.

(b) As the demands for the products from the East increased, the European states wanted to earn more profits and control sea-borne trade. Hence they were interested in investing in the sea exploration.

(c) The spirit of the age that 'let fools contest elections and the adventurous go and explore' prompted many to opt for the latter course that promised both money and fame.

(d) The eagerness to spread religion (Christianity) also acted as an impetus to the exploration of new lands, though this was not a primary factor in the initial period. During the time of the Counter Reformation spreading the word of god gained prominence.

(e) Due to Renaissance there was development of technology in many fields. One such field was cartography (map-making). Ptolemy's map of the first century CE was redrawn using new advances in techniques. A Renaissance geographer, Gerardus Mercator used the concepts of latitude and longitude to draw maps that were useful for the navigators.

(f) A new improved design of ships played a crucial role in the long, risky sea voyages. The building of caravel, a lighter ship that could easily sail in shallow water, was an important technological innovation.

(g) The hazards of sea voyages was mitigated by the availability of firearms and cannons.

(h) Sailors were no longer left to the mercy of a calm night and the bright stars to determine the direction in which they were sailing, since the Mariner's compass was now available in Europe.



Mariner's compass

Initiatives of Portugal



Henry, the Navigator

Located on the south-western part of Europe, the small country of Portugal led the way first in exploration, discovering the Canaries, Madeira and the Azores. In 1442 sailors sent out by Prince Henry, the Navigator reached Guinea Coast of Africa and later in 1488 Bartholomew Diaz rounded the Cape of Good Hope.

Henry, the Navigator was a Portuguese prince. Though he never ventured into the sea, he started a school of navigation at Sagres, Portugal. He hired cartographers, shipbuilders and instrument makers to help sailors undertake planned voyages.

Christopher Columbus (1451–1506)



Columbus

Christopher Columbus, an Italian from Genoa, fought many difficulties before he secured the patronage of the Spanish rulers Ferdinand and Isabella. On 3 August 1492 Columbus sailed from the harbour of Palos near Cadiz, with three small ships (the *Santa Maria*, the *Pinta* and the *Nina*).

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